When the Sea Turns Cold, Rescuers Rush to Save Sea Turtles

From: Science News Explores Mined: 2026-11-13 3 min read

On a cold December afternoon in 2025, Annemarie O'Connell went to a beach in Truro, Massachusetts, near the tip of Cape Cod, with a flashlight to look for sea turtles that had washed up, too cold to swim.

Sea turtles are **reptiles**, so they cannot make their own body heat. They feel best in water from 17 to 29 degrees **Celsius** (62 to 85 degrees Fahrenheit). But if the water drops below 10 degrees **Celsius** (50 degrees Fahrenheit) before they swim south, turtles can get too cold. They grow weak and slow. Some stop swimming and float at the surface. This is called **cold stunning**, and it leaves turtles **dazed** and numb.

Every winter, hundreds of cold-stunned turtles wash up on Massachusetts beaches. Many could not get past Cape Cod. Without help, they may die, but if they reach special hospitals quickly, many survive. Near high tide, O'Connell found a large **loggerhead** about one meter (three feet) long. "It was huge," O'Connell said. Helpers slid it onto a sled and drove it to care.

Word Treasure

reptiles -- Animals with scaly skin that cannot make their own body heat.

cold stunning -- When a sea turtle gets so cold that it grows weak and cannot swim.

loggerhead -- A kind of large sea turtle with a big head.

dazed -- Feeling confused and unable to think or move clearly.

Celsius -- A way to measure how hot or cold something is.

Background you need

Sea turtles are reptiles, so they cannot warm their own bodies and need warm water to stay active and healthy.

When the water gets too cold before they swim south, they can become cold-stunned, which means they grow weak, slow, and numb and may float at the surface.

That is why helpers look for washed-up turtles on beaches and take them to special hospitals, where many can recover.

Break it down

WHO: Annemarie O'Connell and helpers, and a large loggerhead sea turtle
WHAT: O'Connell found the turtle washed up on the beach, too cold to swim, and helpers slid it onto a sled and drove it to care
WHERE: A beach in Truro, Massachusetts, near the tip of Cape Cod
WHY: The water had dropped below 10 degrees Celsius, leaving the turtle dazed and numb, so it needed quick help to survive

Why it matters

Just like you need a warm coat on a freezing day, sea turtles need warm water and quick help to stay alive when winter makes the sea too cold for them.

Test what you remember

1. Why can cold water make sea turtles too cold to swim?

(A) Because sea turtles lose their shells when the water gets cold
(B) Because sea turtles are reptiles and cannot make their own body heat
(C) Because sea turtles drink too much cold seawater
(D) Because sea turtles like to sleep on beaches in winter

2. In what water do sea turtles feel best?

(A) Water colder than 10 degrees Celsius
(B) Water from 17 to 29 degrees Celsius
(C) Water that is frozen at the surface
(D) Water that is much hotter than the sea in summer

3. What does cold stunning do to a sea turtle?

(A) It helps the turtle grow a thicker shell
(B) It makes the turtle weak and slow, and it may stop swimming and float at the surface
(C) It makes the turtle swim much faster toward the south
(D) It turns the turtle's shell bright red

4. Who went to a beach in Truro, Massachusetts, with a flashlight to look for sea turtles?

(A) Annemarie O'Connell
(B) A loggerhead turtle
(C) A team of hospital doctors
(D) A group of schoolchildren

5. What did O'Connell find near high tide?

(A) An empty turtle shell
(B) A large loggerhead about one meter long
(C) A sled with no turtle on it
(D) A small fish hiding under a rock

6. What can happen if cold-stunned turtles reach special hospitals quickly?

(A) They all turn into land turtles
(B) They grow much bigger overnight
(C) They forget how to swim forever
(D) Many survive

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: B 4: A 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):